



Appeal Decision

Site visit made on 10 August 2026

by MG Garrard LLB (Hons), PGDip.LP, Solicitor

an Inspector appointed by the Secretary of State

Decision date: 04 September 2026

Appeal Ref: 6007202

2 Park Farm, Park Road, Westoning, Central Bedfordshire MK45 5LA

- The appeal is made under section 78 of the Town and Country Planning Act 1990 (as amended) against a refusal to grant planning permission.
 - The appeal is made by Mr Graham Honour against the decision of Central Bedfordshire Council.
 - The application Ref is CB/25/03531/FULL.
 - The development proposed is a hay store.
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Decision

1. The appeal is allowed and planning permission is granted for a hay store at 2 Park Farm, Park Road, Westoning, Central Bedfordshire MK45 5LA in accordance with the terms of the application, Ref CB/25/03531/FULL, subject to the following condition:
 - 1) The hay store hereby permitted shall accord with the following approved plan: 2025044-SU-001-A.

Preliminary Matters

2. The appeal relates to development that has already been carried out. I saw the hay store in place during my site visit and have determined the appeal on that basis. I am satisfied that the hay store I observed accords with the development shown on the submitted plan. As 'retrospective' describes the timing of the application rather than the act of development, I have omitted that word from the description of development above.
3. A revised version of the National Planning Policy Framework (the Framework) was published in August 2026. The main parties were given an opportunity to comment on the implications of the revised Framework for the appeal, and I have taken those comments into account in reaching my decision. References to the Framework in my decision are to the August 2026 version.

Main Issue

4. The main issue is:
 - Whether the development is inappropriate development in the Green Belt having regard to the Framework, any relevant development plan policies and taking account of the effect of the development on openness and the purposes of including land within the Green Belt.

Reasons

Inappropriate development

5. The Framework sets out that development in the Green Belt is inappropriate subject to a number of exceptions. Policy GB7 1.f.iv provides that the provision of appropriate facilities (in connection with the existing use of land or a change of use), including buildings, for, amongst other things, outdoor sport and outdoor recreation, is not inappropriate development, provided that the impact on the openness of the Green Belt is minimised and there would not be a significant conflict with the Green Belt purposes. Policy SP4 of the Central Bedfordshire Local Plan 2015-2035 (Adopted July 2021) (CBLP) indicates that development proposals within the Green Belt will be assessed in accordance with government guidance contained in the NPPF¹ and NPPG.²
6. The appeal site is in established equestrian use, with stables, paddocks, a ménage and associated hardstanding, and the Council accepts that the hay store is associated with that use. The keeping and exercising of horses is an outdoor activity that, in my view, amounts to outdoor recreation for the purposes of Policy GB7 1.f.iv. It is unclear why the Council concludes that the proposal falls outside Policy GB7 1.f.iv simply because it takes the form of a building. That policy expressly provides for appropriate facilities, including buildings, in connection with outdoor recreation.
7. The hay store is located within the corner of one of the paddocks, opening onto an area of hardstanding. It is a modest structure whose purpose is the storage of hay to support the equestrian use. Therefore, I find that it constitutes an appropriate facility for outdoor recreation within the meaning of Policy GB7 1.f.iv of the Framework.
8. The site is contained by surrounding residential, equestrian and farm-related development. Although the hay store adds built form, minimising impact on openness does not require land to remain entirely free from development.
9. Visually, the dark timber hay store sits comfortably within its equestrian setting and is seen against the nearby built form, including the rear elevations of properties on Manor Close and their associated domestic paraphernalia. Given its modest scale, appearance and relationship to the existing use, it is not visually intrusive and causes no material harm to visual openness.
10. Spatially, the low single-storey building occupies a very small part of the site and supports the existing equestrian use without materially increasing activity. Its simple form gives it a limited physical presence, so it does not materially diminish spatial openness.
11. The hay store is associated with an established equestrian use within a well-contained site on the edge of the settlement. It does not represent urban sprawl, result in material encroachment into the countryside, contribute to the merging of towns, affect the setting or special character of an historic town, or conflict with urban regeneration objectives.

¹ National Planning Policy Framework

² National Planning Practice Guidance

12. Accordingly, the impact on the openness of the Green Belt is minimised and the development does not conflict with the Green Belt purposes to any material degree, and certainly not to a significant extent.
13. For these reasons, I find that the development is not inappropriate development in the Green Belt having regard to the Framework, any relevant development plan policies and taking account of the effect of the development on openness and the purposes of including land within the Green Belt. Accordingly, it also complies with Policy SP4 of the CBLP with regard to its stipulation that development proposals within the Green Belt will be assessed in accordance with the government guidance contained in the NPPF and NPPG.

Other Matters

14. Concerns have been raised about the retrospective nature of the development and alleged breaches of planning control. Policy DM8.2 of the Framework indicates that where consideration is being given to an application for retrospective planning permission, if it is concluded based on evidence that the unauthorised development was intentional, that fact should be given substantial weight in considering whether to grant planning permission.
15. The appellant's evidence indicates the hay store was moved to its current location to avoid the paddock becoming muddy through repeated access to the store. There is no substantive evidence before me that the development was carried out intentionally to avoid planning control. Therefore, I give limited weight to the fact that the development has already taken place.

Conditions

16. No conditions were suggested by the Council. I have imposed a condition requiring accordance with the approved plan. A commencement condition is unnecessary because the development has already been carried out. Although the Council's landscape officer sought additional planting, the decision report found this unreasonable given the scale and location of the hay store, and I have no reason to disagree. No other conditions are necessary.

Conclusion

17. For the reasons given above, the development is not inappropriate development in the Green Belt and complies with the development plan as a whole. There are no other material considerations of sufficient weight that indicate a decision should be made otherwise than in accordance with it. The appeal is therefore allowed.

MG Garrard

INSPECTOR